

How to Avoid Headaches

Experts suggest a combination of preventive drugs and lifestyle changes to beat the pain



A daily dose of beta blockers or Calcium channel blockers, typically used to treat heart disease, seems to work (strictly under doctor's advice).

Eat regular, healthy meals and on time. Don't skip breakfast. Avoid spicy, oily food. Fasting during festivals is also believed to trigger headaches in India.



Avoid exposure to sunlight. Take protection when going out as much as possible. Heat, humidity and temperatures above 38°C trigger migraine.

Work out. Brisk walking for 20 minutes a day, or jogging, can work wonders. Add

pranayama and yoga to your daily list, to cut down on stress that can spark headaches.



Stay away from food triggers: Chocolate, cheese, ice-cream and coffee often act as headache stimuli.

The headache triggers in India range from mosquito coils to incense sticks and even henna. Try not to use them.



fasting habits among different communities, application of henna, stressful education or careers, tension of commuting in crowded conditions can all contribute to more frequent headaches in India.

That's just the tip of the iceberg, though. Underneath, there's a swarm of myths, misconceptions and lack of knowledge among both patients and doctors. "Treatment of primary headache is often perceived as an unnecessary waste of money by many patients, for a recurrent disorder with no permanent cure," Ravishankar holds. Headaches are often linked to a defect in visual acuity or an emotional disturbance. Add to it the folly of self-medication and the fear of allopathic drugs. Financial constraints and frequent change of doctors also play an adverse role in managing the disorder. But it's not just the patient, not all doctors treating headaches are aware of the recent advances in headache management.

DOCTORS BELIEVE UP TO 70 PER CENT OF HEADACHE PATIENTS CAN BE HELPED WITH TARGETED DRUGS

A class of drugs that emerged in the '90s and is now entering the market in newer avatars, is Triptan. "For many with severe attacks, triptans are the drug of choice," he says. By imitating the action of neurotransmitter serotonin, which regulates mood and pain, it prevents nerve-endings from releasing the excitable proteins. Botox is the other wonder drug that by paralysing the site of injection helps soothe overactive brain signalling. Of the preventive drugs, beta-blockers and calcium channel blockers (typically used to treat hypertension, relieve angina and correct irregular heart beats) are now popular for migraines. They affect the response to nerve impulses, decrease the heart's need for blood and oxygen

by reducing its workload. "New research has found anti-depressants and anti-epilepsy drugs to have a soothing effect on nerve cells, too."

By studying the patients coming to his clinics at Jaslok and Lilavati hospitals, Ravishankar has charted out the first reliable study on the various stimuli that trigger off disabling headaches in India, for the International Headache Society and the WHO. And it also shows how the barriers to treatment lie both with patients as well as doctors. "For instance, some parts of the country can have temperatures of up to 38°C for more than eight months in a year," he points out. Hot and humid weather, increased light and noise levels, different food triggers,

There's a lot one can do to help oneself: spotting individual triggers (caffeine, chocolates or fluorescent lights) and keeping away from them, avoiding excessive reliance on quick fixes, not entering a cycle of daily analgesics. Many swear by various non-pharmacological (see box) methods to keep headaches at bay. These techniques work best for patients whose headaches are triggered by stress. Chances are, however, that more and more patients, like Raj, will eventually hit on the combination of medication and lifestyle changes that works for them. With lots of discipline and a bit of help from science, a headache-free future seems a door you can walk right through. ■